

CHAPTER II

GROWTH OF THE POPULATION

2.1 Population Growth 1871-1971

The total population of Sri Lanka as at the eleventh Census taken on 9th October 1971 was 12,689,897. This represents a five-fold increase over the population of 2,400,380 enumerated a hundred years earlier at the first Census taken on 27th March, 1871. The population enumerated at each of the censuses, the numerical and percentage increase during each intercensal period and the average annual rates of growth in each period are shown in Table 2.1.

It will be noted from the table that there has been a continuous growth in the population of the country, although the rate of growth has not been uniform. The average annual rates of growth during the intercensal periods have varied between 0.9 and 1.7 percent in the period upto 1946. Since 1946 there has been an acceleration in the rates, the highest rate ever recorded being 2.8 percent. The significance of these growth rates lies in the fact that while it took about 55 years for the population of 2 million in 1871 to double itself around 1926, it took only 32 years, from 1931 to 1963 to double itself again. At the 1971 rate of growth of 2.2 percent the population will again double in approximately 35 years. (See Chart 2.1)

TABLE 2.1 : POPULATION, NUMERICAL INCREASE AND PERCENTAGE INCREASE, SRI LANKA 1871-1971

Year	Date of Census	Population*	Numerical increase over previous Census	Percent increase	Average annual rate of growth	Rate of natural increase
1871	March	27	2,400,380	-	-	-
1881	February	17	2,759,738	359,358	15.0	1.4
1891	February	26	3,007,789	248,051	9.0	0.9
1901	March	01	3,565,954	558,165	18.6	1.7
1911	March	10	4,106,350	540,396	15.2	1.4
1921	March	18	4,498,605	392,255	9.6	0.9
1931	February	26	5,306,871	808,266	18.0	1.7
1946	March	19	6,657,339	1,350,468	25.4	1.5
1953	March	20	8,097,895	1,440,556	21.6	2.8
1963	July	08	10,582,064	2,484,169	30.7	2.7
1971	October	09	12,689,897	2,107,833	19.9	2.2

* The population enumerated is the de facto population exclusive of foreign military and shipping personnel.